

Pressure & Stress

Character **First**

SCIENTIFIC FOUNDATION: EVIDENCE PYRAMID

Systematic Review Crocker et al. (2015), review of 92 studies on coping in youth sport confirms that flexible coping strategies (both problem- and emotion-focused) show the strongest relationship with performance and well-being. *International Journal of Sport Psychology*.

RCT Balban et al. (2023), randomized study shows cyclic breathing (4 sec in, 4 sec hold, 8 sec out) significantly reduces stress levels compared to mindfulness meditation. *Cell Reports Medicine*.

Qualitative study Hanton et al. (2009), experiential research with elite athletes: pre-competition anxiety becomes facilitating or debilitating based on how the athlete interprets the stress response, not its intensity.

GUIDANCE PER EXERCISE

- 1 Box Breathing:** Do this together as a group before training. Stand in a circle, close eyes, and lead the breathing rhythm. Say aloud: "In... 2, 3, 4. Hold... 2, 3, 4. Out... 2, 3, 4. Wait... 2, 3, 4." Repeat 4 times. Discuss briefly afterward: "What do you notice?"
- 2 Stress Diary:** This is individual and private. Do not pressure sharing. Say explicitly: "This diary is for you alone. I will not ask what's in it." After two weeks you can ask: "Who has noticed patterns?" without asking for content.
- 3 Worst Case Best Case:** This works in pairs. Pair A writes, Pair B listens. Then switch. The coach asks one question: "Has your Worst Case ever actually happened?" Almost always the answer is no. This relativizing is the goal.

COACH TIPS FOR THIS THEME

Tip 1: Actively normalize stress. Say literally: "Every pro feels this. You too. It's not a weakness." Young players often think they're the only ones who get nervous.

Tip 2: Use Box Breathing in real match situations. During a time-out, give 30 seconds to breathe together before speaking tactically. The result is better information retention.

Tip 3: Watch players who never seem to feel stress. This can be apathy, a defense mechanism. Check in individually: "How is it really going?"

⚠ Beware of increasing pressure by saying "You should be able to handle this." That amplifies exactly the stress you're trying to reduce. Use curious questions: "What do you need to stay calm?"

TIMING

- ☐ Group Box Breathing exercise: 8 minutes
- ☐ Explanation of stress and coping styles: 5 minutes
- ☐ Individual worksheet completion: 10 minutes
- ☐ Worst Case Best Case in pairs: 10 minutes
- ☐ Group reflection and closing: 7 minutes